against a third country, the Singh government explored a diplomatic and maritime quadrilateral with Australia, Japan, and the US. The “quad” did not take off, but the subsequent US-India-Japan trilateral did. India also began an East Asia dialogue with the US, despite concerns in Delhi that it would raise Chinese hackles and drag India into American efforts to counter China.

Some of this criticism about deepening US-India relations and their impact on Indian strategic autonomy had come from the Bharatiya Janata Party. However, when the party returned to power in 2014 under Narendra Modi, it was evident that India’s China challenge was only growing. And the Modi government, too, came to see the US as a significant part of the solution to that problem. It found willing partners in American administrations that once again came to see India vis-à-vis China in a broader Asian context. The Obama administration envisioned India as the linchpin of its pivot or rebalance to Asia.[2] And the Trump administration’s Free and Open Indo-Pacific concept, unveiled in the context of competition with China, only doubled down on a critical role for India. It identified the country as one of the four critical democratic “anchors” in the broader region.[3]

Over the last few years, the US-India relationship has further deepened, particularly in the defense and security realm. The two countries have signed long-negotiated foundational defense agreements that will improve India’s interoperability with the US and its allies. They signed a Joint Strategic Vision on the Asia-Pacific and Indian Ocean Regions, upgraded and expanded the scope of the US-India-Japan trilateral, and revived the quadrilateral consultations. The countries have annual army, special forces, and naval exercises; recently restarted their air force exercise; and participate in each other’s multilateral exercises. India has also gone from making no defense acquisitions from the US to deploying a range of American defense equipment, which was earlier not accessible to it.

Absent a China challenge, it is unlikely that either side would have sought to come this far with the other. Yet, as in the earlier period covered by this book, this cooperation has not progressed in a linear fashion, and it has been contested. Moreover, each side has concerns about the other that have limited their partnership. In Delhi, these revolve around whether the relationship has gone too far, too fast; in Washington, there is